Are these statements right? Discuss with your partner and (√) them if they are correct. Correct them if they are wrong. Share your answers in class.

1. Female Olive Ridleys come ashore at night to lay eggs. ☐
2. The eggs of an Olive Ridley are in the shape and size of a cricket ball. ☐
3. Ridleys come to lay their eggs in the month of January. ☐
4. The turtles use their flippers and make a hollow for their nests. ☐
5. The hatchlings use a tiny egg-tooth to come out of the eggs. ☐

Do you know

There is an interesting aspect of sea turtle biology. The temperature inside the egg determines the sex of the embryo while it is growing. When the eggs develop at 27°C – 28°C only male hatchlings are produced. At 30°C only female hatchlings are produced. An equal mix of male and female hatchlings is produced only when the eggs incubate at precisely 29°C – 30°C.

Section III

Read this section in pairs.

Many of these tiny hatchlings, which weigh less than 20 grams each, will not even reach the sea. They will fall prey to crabs or birds even before they reach the water. Most of those that do make it into the water will also be eaten by many predators in the sea within the first few days of their lives. In fact, scientists estimate that only one in every thousand hatchlings becomes an adult. It is perhaps to ensure that enough hatchlings survive to keep the species going that sea turtles lay so many eggs.

After many years of swimming in the open ocean, the female hatchlings that have become adults return to the same beach where they were born. They come there to lay their own eggs. How they manage to find the place after so many years in the sea is one of the many mysteries of these fascinating reptiles!



Olive Ridley hatchling in the hand

Sea turtles are among the many wonderful creatures we share this planet with.

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